

his family had been musicians through four generations, and his father's post as organist and choirmaster at Lucca's cathedral was regarded as hereditary. Giacomo was only five years old when his father died, but his family was assured he would inherit the job on reaching adulthood. With this future in view, he was taught to play the organ and sing in the choir. But inspired by seeing a performance of a Verdi opera, the young Puccini nourished higher ambitions. In 1880, with his family's backing, he left Lucca to study composition at the Milan Conservatory.

Success, failure, and scandal

Puccini was a vain and self-centered young man with an undisciplined, lazy streak that was often the despair of his teachers. Nevertheless, his talent proved indisputable. His instrumental composition *Capriccio sinfonico*, performed at his graduation from the Conservatory in 1883, attracted the attention of Milan's musical elite. In the same year, his one-act opera *Le Villi* failed to win a competition prize, but his Milanese friends funded a revised two-act version the following year that won modest acclaim. Puccini was signed by the prominent music publisher Giulio Ricordi. Despite the crushing failure of his second opera *Edgar* when it premiered at La Scala in 1889, his career was now launched.

Meanwhile, Puccini's private life was racked by scandal. The death of his mother in 1884 brought the grieving son back to Lucca. There he fell in love with Elvira Gemignani (née Bonturi), a married woman. Their affair was kept secret until 1886, when Elvira became pregnant with Puccini's child. Reviled as a